Cleaning Cots at the Shelter

Instructions for the steps needed to effectively clean cots after they have been used in shelters

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Disaster Health Services

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Considerations

- Shelter workers are responsible for cleaning the cots assigned to a shelter.
- Following standardized procedures is necessary to ensure that cots are sanitary, do not endanger others' health, and are ready for use by a future client.
  - Improper cleaning of cots may lead to mildew and damage.
  - Disinfecting cots incorrectly may lead to infection risks.
- All cots are to be clean and dry prior to the shelter closing, and all cots that have been used must be cleaned and returned to stock prior to the DRO ending.

What to do

Determine where cots will be cleaned

- Identify a well-ventilated location where cots can be cleaned.
  - Whenever possible, use a tent or covered area.
- When space, restrictions, or resources do not allow the cots to be cleaned at the shelter, the HQ Sheltering Manager will coordinate with Logistics to move cots to an off-site location.

Gather necessary supplies

- Nitrile gloves
- Face masks

- Coveralls
- Scrub brush
- Dish soap
- Hospital-grade disinfectant solution or wipes (e.g., Clorox Healthcare Hydrogen Peroxide Disinfectant Wipes)
    - Ensure the product is EPA-registered and appears on the EPA List N. Follow the manufacturer's instructions for contact time.
- Water hose attachment

Clean and disinfect cots

Cots that have been used by clients

- Follow the safety directions of the disinfectant solution manufacturer and wear gloves, a mask, and plastic coveralls while cleaning a cot to protect the skin from exposure.
- Sweep off any debris or vacuum the exterior surfaces of the cot.
- Spray-wash each cot with a water hose sprayer attachment.
- Brush the entire cot with a scrub brush or cloth using a solution of liquid dishwashing detergent and water.
    - Replace cloths frequently when using a cloth.
- Rinse the entire cot thoroughly with clean water to remove all detergent residue.
- Allow the cot to dry, or wipe/shake off any standing water, so the surface is no more than slightly damp before disinfecting.
    - Applying disinfectant to a wet cot dilutes the solution and reduces its effectiveness.
- Disinfect the cot with hospital-grade disinfectant solution spray or wipes. Follow the instructions on the disinfectant's label, including the required wet contact time — the surface must stay visibly wet with disinfectant for the full time listed.
- Allow the cot to air dry for at least 24 hrs.
    - Place the cot in sunlight, if possible.
    - Longer drying times may be needed in humid environments.
- Return the clean, dried, usable cots to the original bag sleeve and/or cardboard box.

Cots that have been set up but not used by clients

- Cots that have been opened but not used should be visually inspected to confirm they remain clean and do not require full cleaning and disinfection.
- Disinfect the clean cots by either spraying the cot with hospital-grade disinfectant solution or using hospital-grade disinfectant wipes.
- Follow the instructions on the disinfectant's label.
- Allow a few minutes for rapid drying.
- Return the cot to the original bag sleeve and/or cardboard box.
- Return to the shelter trailer or stack as directed for pick-up.

Engage Disaster Health Services or Public Health for situation-specific guidance when cots have been exposed to blood, urine, bowel movements or other unique germs

- It may be necessary to utilize other cleaning and disinfectant approaches or salvage certain cots.

Prepare cleaned cots for return to storage

- Mark cots to identify those that are:
    - clean and ready for storage
    - broken and need to be disposed of with medical waste
    - broken and can be disposed of with general garbage
- Update the inventory sheet to reflect the number of discarded cots.
- Return to the shelter trailer or stack as directed for pick-up.

Moving cots to another location to be cleaned

Prepare the cots for movement

- Each cot must be clearly marked as “dirty” before being removed from the shelter and cleaned elsewhere.
- Sweep off any debris or vacuum the exterior surfaces of the cot.
- Do not place dirty cots in bag sleeves or boxes.

Relocating cots for cleaning

- Establish a plan and designate an accountable Red Cross leader to ensure that dirty cots are not mixed with clean cots during the move and are cleaned before the end of the DRO.
- When dirty cots have been placed in a regional shelter trailer prior to being cleaned, post prominent signage inside and outside the shelter trailer indicating the cots are dirty so that they are not accidentally used for a future response.
- Vehicles such as ERVs actively being used to transport food should not be used to transport dirty cots.

Related Articles

Coordinating the Closing or Consolidation of Shelters
Guidance for sheltering leadership on necessary steps to take in advance of closing shelters

Closing a Shelter Site
Instructions for planning for and implementing the closing of a shelter site.

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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